

St. Paisios on committing to regular church attendance and confession:

1. On Regular Church Attendance: "Do Not Forsake the Assembly of the Saints" (Heb. 10:25)

a) Prioritize Sundays Like a Spiritual Lifeline

"Just as your body needs weekly food, your soul needs the Liturgy. Skipping it is like starving your soul while feeding only your belly."

"Even if you feel 'dry' or distracted in church, go anyway. The grace of the Mysteries works invisibly, like rain on parched soil."

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 1: With Pain and Love for Modern Man

b) Prepare Your Heart Beforehand

"Don't rush into church like a gust of wind. Wake up 10 minutes earlier, read a Psalm, and say: *'I will enter Your house, O Lord' (Ps. 5:7). This quiets the mind."

"If you're late, don't let shame keep you away. God rejoices more over your arrival than a shepherd over a lost sheep."

Oral advice to pilgrims (recorded in "Words of Life")

c) Participate Actively, Not Passively

"Don't just 'attend' Liturgy — offer yourself. Unite your prayers to the priest's, your sighs to the hymns. Even standing reverently is a prayer."

"When you hear *'Let us lift up our hearts,'* leave your worldly cares at the door like old shoes."

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

2. On Regular Confession: "Confess Your Sins to One Another" (James 5:16)

a) Treat Confession as Spiritual Surgery

"Confession isn't a shameful interrogation—it's a hospital. You wouldn't hide a festering wound from a doctor; don't hide sins from Christ through your priest."

"The devil will whisper, 'This sin is too small to confess' or 'Too big to be forgiven.'* Ignore him. No wound is too small to infect you, nor too big for God's mercy."

"Passions and Virtues" (Holy Monastery of St. Paisios)

b) Prepare with Specificity

"Don't say, 'I'm a sinner'—name the sin. 'I yelled at my wife, I watched impurity, I harbored hatred.' This cuts out the rot."

"Write sins down if you forget them, but burn the paper afterward—don't let it become a record of shame."

Advice to spiritual children (Epistles)

c) Return Frequently, Even for "Small" Sins

"Like washing dirty hands daily, don't let sins accumulate. Monthly confession is good, but if you're drowning in passion, go weekly."

"A priest isn't there to judge you but to say: *'God has forgiven you—now go fight harder.'"

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 4: Family Life

3. Overcoming Excuses (His Most Practical Advice)

For Church Attendance:

"If you say, 'I'm too tired,' remember: One hour in church gives more rest to your soul than three hours of extra sleep."

"If you say, 'I don't get anything out of it,' ask yourself: 'How much did I put into it? Did I prepare? Did I pray?'"

For Avoiding Confession:

"If you're ashamed, remember: The priest has heard worse, and heaven rejoices more over one repentant sinner than 99 'righteous' men (Lk. 15:7)."

"If you think, 'I'll confess later,'* reply to the devil: 'Now is the day of salvation' (2 Cor. 6:2)."

Various oral teachings

4. The Fruits of Faithfulness

"Those who prioritize church and confession are like trees planted by streams (Ps. 1:3)—their roots drink grace, and they bear fruit even in droughts."

"Regular confession doesn't just 'forgive'—it *transforms*. Over time, you'll hate the sins you once loved."

Spiritual Counsels Vol. 2: Spiritual Awakening

Key Takeaway:

Church: Go even when you don't 'feel' it. Grace works invisibly."*

Confession: Be honest, be frequent, and never despair."

Battle Plan: Schedule services like a doctor's appointment for your soul.

Cancel worldly plans before canceling Liturgy."

A Christian who neglects church and confession is like a soldier who skips meals and never cleans his weapon—he'll faint in battle."